

Young Trilateral Leaders

Regional Cooperation Roundtable Gwangju Final Report

November 15-16, 2025

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Ⅰ. Executive Summary

Sustaining U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral cooperation increasingly requires engagement beyond central governments. While national-level diplomacy remains essential, it cannot ensure the depth and continuity needed for a long-term relationship amid evolving political and strategic dynamics on its own. Embedding trilateral cooperation across subnational actors, including local governments, universities, and youth communities, is therefore critical to translating national alignment into sustained, people-to-people engagement and locally grounded policy innovation. Within this context, Gwangju represents a capable yet underutilized subnational actor. The Young Trilateral Leaders (YTL) convened the Gwangju American Corner workshop to examine how locally anchored engagement can reinforce and complement national-level trilateral cooperation.

Ⅱ. Assessing Gwangju's Potential Role in Trilateral Cooperation

During the workshop, YTL alumni and Gwangju-based youth participants examined how subnational leadership can reinforce long-term trilateral stability. Discussions highlighted several defining characteristics of Gwangju that position the city as a meaningful contributor to U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral engagement.

Engagement with local youth revealed a strong interest in international dialogue despite structural constraints associated with geographic distance from Seoul. Participants, including youths who traveled from neighboring regions, underscored unmet demand for sustained and structured engagement opportunities. While participants demonstrated high levels of civic awareness and familiarity with global issues, they also noted limited access to long-term, actionable platforms compared to other metropolitan areas.

Discussions further indicated that Gwangju maintains a strong sense of regional identity rooted in its historical and civic legacy, while remaining generally receptive to expanded trilateral cooperation. Participants acknowledged the city's long-standing emphasis on regional autonomy, alongside concerns related to population decline and continued out-migration to Seoul. Many emphasized that trilateral cooperation would gain broader legitimacy and public support if regional perspectives were more systematically incorporated into policy-making processes.

At the same time, participants raised nuanced concerns regarding cooperation with Japan, shaped by historical memory and Gwangju's civic identity. These views were not expressed as opposition to trilateral cooperation, but rather as a call for more transparent, inclusive, and locally informed engagement processes. Notably, younger participants articulated a pragmatic reassessment of trilateral cooperation, citing evolving regional security dynamics, including increased coordination among North Korea, China, and Russia, as reinforcing the strategic importance of trilateral collaboration.

Participants also expressed concern that trilateral decision-making remains overly centralized in Washington, Tokyo, and Seoul, limiting meaningful regional participation. Taken together, these perspectives underscored the importance of subnational engagement as a mechanism for addressing historical sensitivities, building trust, and strengthening the legitimacy and durability of U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral cooperation.

Ⅲ. Proposed Areas of Cooperation

Gwangju–San Antonio–Sendai Trilateral City Youth Congress

- Gwangju is home to the oldest American Corner in the Republic of Korea and has long been recognized for its historical, cultural, and economic significance. Despite this legacy, Gwangju remains comparatively underrepresented in trilateral youth-focused diplomacy initiatives. While cities such as Seoul, supported by dense diplomatic and international ecosystems, and Busan, host of the 2024 YTL Summit, have benefited from sustained trilateral engagement, Gwangju has not received a proportional level of attention or resource mobilization in the youth diplomacy space.

  This gap has prompted alternative regional initiatives, including programs led by the Trilateral Cooperation Secretariat (TCS), to partially fill the void through targeted activities such as the 2023 Korean Culture Cities of East Asia (CCEA) Networking Event. Establishing a trilateral youth diplomacy program in Gwangju would directly address this imbalance.

  Building on Gwangju's existing bilateral sister-city relationships with San Antonio and Sendai, the proposed Gwangju–San Antonio–Sendai Youth Congress would formalize trilateral cooperation at the municipal level through a memorandum of understanding (MOU). The proposal leverages existing collaboration networks, including the annual youth camps conducted by the Gwangju International Center (GIC) with San Antonio and Sendai since 2024, making trilateral expansion operationally feasible.

  To ensure meaningful youth participation, the proposal recommends institutionalizing a mandatory Youth Hearing Session, attended by accredited youth delegates from each city. This session would serve as a deliberative mechanism through which youth participants review, propose, and refine program priorities, ensuring that local perspectives are substantively integrated into decision-making processes. This bottom-up model positions youth not as passive beneficiaries, but as contributors to trilateral cooperation.

Tourism and Arts Cooperation

- Gwangju's cultural heritage, artistic legacy, and democratic history position the city as a distinctive driver of inclusive tourism development. While Seoul remains the dominant hub of global K-culture, Gwangju offers an alternative narrative grounded in creativity, community, and civic values.

Trilateral cooperation presents an opportunity to elevate Gwangju's global profile while reinforcing locally rooted cultural development. Expanding Gwangju's bilateral cultural exchanges with San Antonio and Sendai into a tri-city framework would enable shared programming among schools, artists, and local communities.

Participants proposed the development of a narrative-based cross-city tourism route highlighting shared heritage, gastronomy, and creative industries. In parallel, the Asia Culture Center (ACC) could host a trilateral Local Artist Co-Creation Series, bringing together emerging artists to reinterpret local identity through collaborative production.

The proposal also addressed the forthcoming Hyundai Gwangju complex (anticipated in 2027), recognizing both its economic potential and associated social concerns. To mitigate risks of cultural displacement, participants proposed a Local Merchant Co-Branding Studio pairing small business owners with design, marketing, and tourism students from the three countries. This initiative would ensure that large-scale development amplifies, rather than replaces, Gwangju's local identity.

Cooperation in Emerging Technologies and Economic Security

- **Energy Storage Systems (ESS)**
  As an emerging AI hub, Gwangju faces increasing demand for stable, clean energy to support data centers and advanced computing infrastructure. Energy Storage Systems (ESS) were identified as a critical enabling technology to address intermittency challenges associated with renewable energy.

  Gwangju's designation as a Green Energy ESS Sandbox Zone, combined with proximity to institutions such as GIST, KENTECH, and KEPCO, positions the city as a viable center for ESS development. However, participants noted gaps in clean energy governance and specialized human resources relative to Japan and the United States.

  Japan's leadership in solid-state and sodium-sulfur battery technologies, as well as municipal-level models such as Sakai City's net-zero energy initiatives, offers valuable lessons. In the United States, states including Texas and Georgia provide complementary strengths in renewable deployment and STEM talent. Trilateral collaboration among Gwangju, Osaka, San Antonio, and U.S. partner regions could advance joint test-beds, governance frameworks, and workforce exchanges, positioning Gwangju as a subnational hub for trilateral clean-energy cooperation.

- **Artificial Intelligence (AI)**
  Gwangju hosts major AI infrastructure, including the National AI Data Center opened in late 2024 and is operated by NHN Cloud. Coordination between Gwangju City and Jeollanam-do Province has further accelerated investment in data centers and AI development.

San Antonio similarly represents a growing AI data center hub in the United States, supported by strong biotech, healthcare, and business ecosystems. As AI demand increases, both cities face parallel challenges related to energy consumption and sustainability. Building on the 2010 Gwangju–San Antonio MOU on eco-friendly industries, participants emphasized the importance of integrating ESS and renewable energy into AI infrastructure planning.

- **Drones**

  Drones were identified as a strategic area of cooperation for both national security and agricultural productivity. Gwangju and Sendai face similar demographic challenges in aging farming populations, while the United States continues to reassess supply chain dependencies in drone manufacturing.

  Sendai's integration of drone technology into agriculture, supported by firms such as Kisui Tech, offers a model for enhancing productivity. Opportunities for trilateral cooperation include joint research, STEM education exchanges, and youth-led pilot projects involving institutions such as Chonnam National University, Tohoku University, and the University of Texas at San Antonio. Such initiatives would strengthen people-to-people ties while diversifying supply chains and reinforcing trilateral resilience.

Ⅳ. Key Outcomes and Insights

- **Program Outcomes:** A total of fourteen participants attended the program, with eight Young Trilateral Leaders alumni serving as speakers. Post-program survey results indicate strong outcomes, with **93.3%** of participants reporting high overall satisfaction with the program (4–5 out of 5), **73.3%** reporting a high level of understanding of **U.S.–ROK–Japan cooperation** following participation (4–5), and **93.3%** indicating increased interest in and a clearer recognition of the importance and value of trilateral cooperation.

- **Outreach Metrics:** In the Gwangju region, the team conducted outreach to 6 institutions, engaging 17 administrative offices and academic departments, 7 faculty members, 4 student organizations, and 3 media and public institutions. These efforts established **25+** direct contact points, creating a sustainable outreach network to support follow-on engagement and advance subnational, people-to-people cooperation aligned with U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral objectives.*(see Appendix C*)

- **Gabi Kim:** The Gwangju convening highlighted the strong commitment and latent demand among regional youth for participation in international dialogue, reinforcing the rational15e for the TogetherWeTri team's focus on regional cooperation. Participants traveled from outside the city specifically to attend the program, and discussions demonstrated both substantive engagement and a sense of responsibility regarding balanced national development, particularly concerns about population outflow to Seoul. At the same time, younger participants expressed a

relatively open and forward-looking perspective on U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral cooperation, acknowledging unresolved issues in the ROK–Japan relationship while emphasizing the strategic importance of strengthening trilateral ties for the future. These observations underscore that place-based engagement outside major metropolitan centers can generate deeper participation, surface locally grounded concerns, and foster stronger ownership of trilateral cooperation than capital-centered programming, thereby enhancing the long-term relevance and sustainability of subnational engagement.

- **Seungbeom Ryan Son**: As the inaugural TogetherWeTri convening, the Gwangju workshop demonstrated the value of locally grounded trilateral youth engagement, with participants moving quickly from general discussions to applied policy issues such as information-sharing, crisis coordination, and technology governance. Discussions reflected a pragmatic assessment of trilateral cooperation, separating domestic political preferences from regional problem-solving needs, and emphasized the importance of continuity beyond one-time engagement. Repeated calls for follow-up mechanisms and structured opportunities to develop policy ideas underscored the need for sustained, subnational platforms for trilateral cooperation.

- **Seoyoung Lee**: Beginning the first journey of #TogetherWeTri in Gwangju felt profoundly meaningful, setting the tone for how regional cooperation can meaningfully shape the next chapter of trilateral cooperation. To begin with, the AC site itself was filled with passionate, youthful energy, energized by YTL members' insightful presentations and the creative ideas shared by local university students. In particular, when we discussed the connection between 'Trilateral' and 'Gwangju', it was valuable to hear the voices of local participants and understand how regional cooperation can be specialized and rooted in the city's own identity. Throughout the workshop, we explored a wide spectrum of topics—from soft power and Hallyu to history, politics, and education. All discussions ultimately tied back to the core values of cooperation, and from there, we expanded outward to consider how Gwangju can play a more active role within the trilateral landscape. Moreover, on Day 2, our policy proposal session allowed for a deeper dive into practical and emerging ideas, including technology, cultural identity, and people-to-people exchange. In conclusion, the ACC cultural excursion, especially the exhibition on democratic voices and spring uprisings, further reinforced the mindset that YTL members are emerging leaders who must carry forward these values with responsibility and imagination.

- **SeungHwan Kim**: When we discussed trilateralism, we mostly talked about national-level cooperation, but we often neglected trilateral cooperation at the state or provincial level. As political volatility among the three nations persists, the sustainability and endurance of trilateralism are at stake, underscoring the role of bottom-up cooperation in sustaining this momentum. In that sense, Gwangju deeply aligns with the purpose and values of trilateral cooperation. Upholding democratic values, cooperating on emerging technologies, and highlighting people-to-people exchange are major characteristics the city emphasizes, proving how well it suits provincial-level trilateral cooperation. If the city continues to find areas of cooperation among the three countries in various aspects, I have no doubt about Gwangju becoming a major hub for a bottom-up U.S.-ROK-Japan trilateral cooperation.

- **Jaewon Kim**: Based on the concerns outlined above, I propose supporting the internalization of Gwangju's evolving identity in a way that enables the city to more fully endorse and participate in U.S.–ROK–Japan trilateral cooperation. This requires shifting from a top-down approach, driven primarily by decision-making in Washington, Tokyo, and Seoul, to a bottom-up model that empowers local communities to actively shape and advance trilateral relations. Considering the anxieties expressed by residents regarding population decline and the erosion of community life, trilateral cooperation could also be strengthened through city-to-city partnerships among communities facing similar challenges in all three countries—such as a Gwangju–Fukushima–Detroit triangle. Shared difficulties and differing perspectives among these communities would foster solidarity and generate valuable mutual insights, thereby broadening and deepening the foundations of trilateral cooperation.

- **Byungjoon You**: This bottom-up trilateral engagement highlighted strong interest among youth across regions, including Gwangju, in expanded opportunities for participation. Discussions also underscored that the limited availability of formalized engagement structures—particularly at the subnational level—has created space for other initiatives, such as the Trilateral Cooperation Secretariat (TCS), to fill this gap. These observations point to the need for the Young Trilateral Leaders (YTL) initiative to further expand and institutionalize locally grounded engagement channels. The workshop also demonstrated the value of anchoring trilateral activities in local contexts. Gwangju's active youth participation, historical significance—including the establishment of the Republic of Korea's first American Corner—and strong community engagement reinforced the benefits of regionally based programming. Moving forward, the development of recurring, locally anchored programs, supported by clearer guidance for youth-led follow-up activities, would strengthen the sustainability, inclusiveness, and long-term impact of YTL engagement.

- **Soren Israel Dickson:** I found exploring the harder numbers and deliverables aspect of trilateral cooperation to be fascinating and a worthwhile thought exercise in expanding this relationship beyond words and statements. In particular, the emphasis on ESS and its relation to Gwangju seemed particularly insightful, and challenged me to think more specifically about expanding trilateral cooperation on a micro level. I found the overall workshop itself to be enjoyable and well-paced, and my favorite thing was getting to connect with locals and spend time with the other YTL participants. I believe there are still several barriers to subnational trilateral cooperation, but the overlapping incentives outlined at the workshop indicate that if this relationship becomes codified, the incentives for greater cooperation are present. Overall, I thoroughly enjoyed this experience and was very glad I was able to participate.

- **Hyoseo Nam:** In contrast to similar engaging events held in cities such as Busan and Seoul, which have typically been limited to youth with comparable academic backgrounds, the Gwangju workshop stood out for attracting participants of diverse age groups and professional fields. During the roundtable discussions, participants demonstrated a strong sense of civic responsibility by candidly expressing concerns as a Gwangju citizen regarding the pace of regional development, the effectiveness of policy implementation, and time lags between policy design

and execution. Moreover, as a city that has long fostered vibrant dialogue in the fields of democracy, civic activism, and human rights—and as part of the Honam region where widely recognized as Korea's representative "culinary capital"—Gwangju is well positioned to serve as a source of global symbolic capital for trilateral cooperation.

Ⅴ. Monitoring and Evaluation

The Gwangju American Corner workshop generated substantive analysis, actionable policy proposals, and a shared understanding of how subnational engagement can advance U.S.–ROK–Japan cooperation. Discussions reinforced that cities such as Gwangju can function not as passive participants in international affairs, but as proactive partners capable of supporting durable trilateral cooperation.

By anchoring trilateral initiatives in local contexts, empowering youth as stakeholders, and aligning emerging technology cooperation with regional strengths, the Gwangju model demonstrates a scalable approach to strengthening trilateral cooperation beyond central government channels. The outcomes of this workshop will inform future TogetherWeTri convenings and contribute to the development of sustained, bottom-up trilateral engagement.

VI. **Appendix**

Appendix A. Photos and Videos

		
Opening	**Seungbeom Son (Moderator)**	**Opening Remarks**
		
Jaewon Kim	**Soren Dickson**	**Hyoseo Nam**
		
Byungjoon You	**Seunghwan Kim**	**Gabi Kim**


GWANGJU AMERICAN CORNER
광주아메리칸코너

Group Photo


GWANGJU AMERICAN CORNER
광주아메리칸코너

Policy Proposal Meeting		
		

[TogehterWeTri_Gwangju AC Workshop Video]

Appendix B. Poster



Appendix C. Outreach Contact Inventory (Gwangju Region)

Region	Insitution	Details	Contacts
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Office of External Relations / External Affairs	062-530-1278
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Office of Career Development	062-530-1111
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Department of English Language and Literature	062-530-5114 / hhb@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Department of Political Science and Internationa	062-530-2620
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	University Press / Campus Newspaper	062-530-0523
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	English Conversation Club	https://www.instagram.com/esu_jnu/
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	UNSA (United Nations Student Association)	https://www.instagram.com/unsa_cnu
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Office of International Cooperation	0625300679 / yyr9652@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Office of Language Education Institute	062-530-0500 / jnukorean@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Broadcasting Station / Media Center	062-530-0523/0527 / press@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Graduate School of Cultural Studies	cult@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Office of International Affairs	underia@jnu.ac.kr(undergraduate), internia
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Chonnam Tribune (English-language Magazine)	cnumedia@cnumedia.com
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Professor Jin Hwal-min, Department of PSIR	hminjin@chonnam.edu
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Professor Choi Eun-jung, Department of PSIR	ejchoi76@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Professor Kim Min-hyuk, Department of PSIR	mk841@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Associate Professor Seo Il-won, Regional Devel	veny.seo@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Assistant Professor Hwang Jae-hee, Regional D	j.hwang@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Professor Kim Myung-sung, Department of Engl	mkim105@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chonnam National University	Chair Na Yoon-hee, Department of English Lang	yhna04@jnu.ac.kr
Gwangju	Chosun University	Han Ji-sung, President, Student Council, Depart	010-9278-1789
Gwangju	Chosun University	Office of International Cooperation	062-230-6497
Gwangju	Chosun University	Office of Student Affairs and Career Services	062-230-7574
Gwangju	Chosun University	Department of Political Science and Internationa	062.230.6709
Gwangju	Chosun University	University Press / Campus Newspaper	062-230-6162
Gwangju	Gwangju International Center	Jo Sae-rom, Administrative Officer, External Rel	062-226-2734 / gic@gic.or.kr
Gwangju	Kwnagju Foreign School	Office of Academic Affairs	secretary@kwangjufs.org
Gwangju	Asian Culture Center	Service Operations Team	062-601-4758
Gwangju	Asian Culture Center	Date Check	062-601-4057

**Submitted to U.S. Department of State in Washington D.C & U.S. Embassy Seoul Reporting*


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